

Amphisbaenians

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Reptilia
ORDER	Squamata
SUBORDER	Amphisbaenia
FAMILIES	6
SPECIES	196

Although they are sometimes called “worm lizards,” amphisbaenians are neither worms nor lizards. They are, however, closely related to lizards and belong to the same order as both lizards and snakes. Adapted to an underground life, amphisbaenians are seen above ground only after heavy rain has flooded their tunnels. Their ability to regulate body temperature is limited, which confines them to tropical and subtropical regions.

Anatomy

Amphisbaenians are wormlike in appearance with cylindrical bodies and rings of scales that look like body segments. They have rudimentary eyes and smooth heads that look wedge-shaped in side view. They are all without legs, except for 3 species that have front limbs, positioned close to the head and ending in long claws for burrowing. Many amphisbaenians lack pigmentation and are pinkish brown; a few are more colorful.

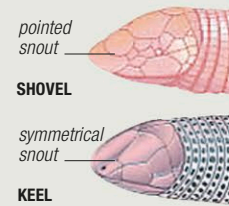
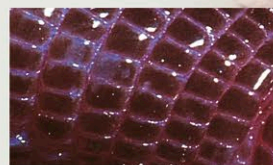
SCALES

Unlike the scales of snakes, which overlap each other, those of amphisbaenians are arranged in concentric rings.



EYES AND EARS

An amphisbaenian's eyes are covered with translucent skin, and like many burrowing animals, they have poor vision. They lack external ear openings.



HEAD SHAPE

Amphisbaenians use their thick, heavy skulls to dig tunnels. The shape of the snout varies according to the method of tunneling.

Tunneling

Amphisbaenians construct their own burrows, down which they move in search of worms, insects, and larvae. They make fresh tunnels by using their skulls as rams. Their nostrils point backward, and are thus prevented from being clogged up with soil while burrowing. The lower jaw is recessed, so that, as the head is forced through the soil, the mouth is held tightly closed.



LIMBS

Amphisbaenians spend almost all their lives underground, burrowing in soil, sand, or leaf litter. Most have lost all traces of limbs. However, the members of one family, the Mexican worm lizards (shown here), have retained their forelimbs.

Amphisbaena fuliginosa

Speckled worm lizard



Length 12–18 in (30–45 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Not evaluated

Location N. South America, Trinidad



This South American species is one of the most easily recognized amphisbaenians because of its



conspicuous markings. It lives almost exclusively in burrows (although it may come to the surface at night), using its head to ram a tunnel through the ground and its body rings to help it concertina through the tunnel. It feeds on virtually any small vertebrates and insects, attacking them with its strong jaws. If threatened, it may shed part of its tail, which does not regenerate. Like other amphisbaenians, this species is difficult to study since it spends most of its life underground.

Bipes biporus

Ajolote

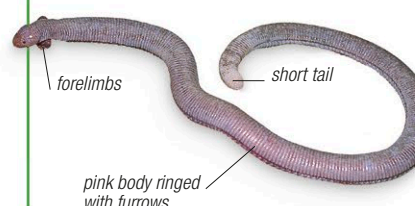


Length 6½–9½ in (17–24 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Least concern

Location Mexico (Baja California)



The ajolote, or mole lizard, is one of the world's most remarkable reptiles. It has the typical amphisbaenian adaptations for a life spent burrowing—a blunt head, cylindrical body, and short tail—but it also has a pair of very short yet powerful front legs. Equipped with clawed feet, they help the ajolote to excavate its way through the ground. The ajolote rarely comes to the surface—and then only after heavy rain—and it feeds by ambushing lizards and other small animals, usually dragging them underground. There are 2 similar species, also found only in Mexico.



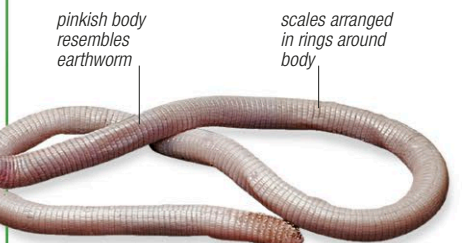
Rhineura floridana

Florida worm lizard



Length 10–14 in (25–35 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Least concern

Location S.E. USA (Florida)



The Florida worm lizard looks like an earthworm, with a pinkish body that has no limbs, no external eyes, and no ear openings. Exceptional specimens can be up to 16 in (40 cm) long. The scales are ill-defined and arranged in rings around the cylindrical body. This worm lizard leads its life almost entirely underground but may be forced to the surface because of heavy rain or ploughing. An opportunistic species, it feeds on invertebrates encountered while burrowing. It is preyed upon by birds—mockingbirds occasionally unearth it when hunting for earthworms.

Blanus cinereus

European worm lizard



Length 4–8 in (10–20 cm), max 12 in (30 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Least concern

Location S.W. Europe



The European worm lizard has a small, pinkish or purplish brown body, with a short head, pointed snout, rudimentary eyes, and ringlike grooves, all of which



help it burrow. Mostly found under rocks and logs, it may appear on the surface at night, especially after heavy rain. It hunts along underground tunnels for earthworms and small insects. *Blanus tingitanus*, found in Morocco and Algeria, used to be considered the same species.